

Lesson 8: Build Social Proof

Course 16: Build Your Professional Identity — Final Lesson

What You'll Do Today

Your portfolio is live. Today you'll do two things: learn how to ask real people for honest feedback about your work (the right way), and run a full quality check on your site so it's actually ready for someone to visit.

Why This Matters

Anyone can say their work is great. What makes people actually believe you is **credibility** — proof that comes from a real person, about a real project, that anyone could go check for themselves. One honest sentence from your robotics teacher who watched you build something is worth more than ten fake five-star reviews, because it's real, specific, and checkable. You don't need a lot of proof. You need *true* proof.

Real Social Proof vs. Fake Social Proof

Social proof is evidence that other people trust or value your work. An **endorsement** is a specific form of social proof: a real person, in their own words, saying something true about work they actually saw.

Real, ethical social proof	Fake / manufactured social proof (never do this)
A teacher writes one honest sentence about a project they saw	Writing a "quote" yourself and attributing it to someone
A mentor's short note about work they actually reviewed	Asking strangers online to praise work they never saw
A link to your real GitHub repo or live site — the proof is the work itself	A testimonial with a stock photo and a made-up name
"This site has been live 6 months and my club still uses it" (checkable fact)	Vague claims like "loved by hundreds!" with nothing behind them
A quote the person reviewed and approved before you posted it	Editing a real quote to say more than the person meant

The rule for your whole career, not just this lesson: if the words didn't come from a real person who actually saw the work, and they haven't approved how you're using it, it does not go on your site. Ever. An empty "social proof" section, or one that says "coming soon," is always better than a fake one.

Worked Example

A real endorsement-request message (fictional student "Jordan R.")

Subject: Quick favor — would you write a short line about my study-tracker app?

Hi Ms. Alvarez,

I'm finishing up my coding portfolio for a class, and I wanted to ask if you'd be willing to write a short, honest sentence or two about the study-tracker app I built for the robotics club. It doesn't need to be long — just your real impression, good or constructive. I'll show you exactly how it'll appear before I post anything.

No worries at all if you'd rather not — totally understand.

Thanks either way, Jordan

A real endorsement received (fictional example)

"Jordan built our club's study-tracker app as a side project, and it's still the tool we use to plan meeting schedules two years later. It's simple, it works, and Jordan kept improving it based on our feedback." — Ms. Alvarez, Robotics Club Advisor

Notice: it's short, it's specific (names the actual project and how long it's lasted), and it's attributed to a real, named person. That's what makes it credible — not its length or enthusiasm.

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Social proof	Evidence that other people trust or value your work
Endorsement	A real person's own words, about work they actually saw, given with their permission
Credibility	How believable and trustworthy something appears, based on real, checkable evidence
Integrity	Doing the honest thing even when a shortcut (like faking a quote) would look better in the moment

Step-by-Step Activity

1. **Pick one real person** who has actually seen one of your portfolio projects: a teacher, coach, mentor, club advisor, or parent.
2. **Draft your own endorsement-request message** using the template on your Worksheet. Name the specific project. Keep it short. Give them an easy way to say no.
3. **Run a full portfolio QA pass** on your live site using the checklist on your Worksheet: check every link, reread every sentence for typos, view your site on a phone-size screen, and confirm your listed contact method is safe (school email or a contact form — not a home address or personal cell number).

4. **Fix everything you find.** Redeploy to Vercel if you make changes.
5. **Complete the course-completion reflection** at the end of your Worksheet.

Sending your endorsement-request message is optional homework — it depends on a real person being available — but the QA pass and reflection are required today.

Knowledge Checks

1. What is the main difference between social proof and fake/manufactured social proof?
2. Why can having zero testimonials on your portfolio right now still be a trustworthy choice?
3. Name two things a good endorsement-request message should include.
4. Before you publish someone's quote on your site, what must you always do first?
5. List two things you should check for in a final portfolio QA pass.

Reflection Prompts

1. Who is one real person who could honestly speak to your work, and why did you choose them?
2. What's one thing you fixed during your QA pass that you wouldn't have noticed without checking carefully?
3. Why does it matter — for your future career, not just this class — that you never fabricate a testimonial?

Submission Instructions

Submit, via the class Google Doc or your assigned submission link: - A screenshot or copy of your drafted endorsement-request message - Your completed portfolio QA checklist (from the Worksheet) - Your completed course-completion reflection - The live URL of your final, polished portfolio

Course 16 Complete — What's Next

You now have a live, honest, professional portfolio that you built and can stand behind completely. That's a real accomplishment. In **Course 17: Skills That Pay**, you'll take this exact portfolio and start turning it into real opportunities — understanding freelancing basics, how to price your own work, and how to land your first paid or resume-worthy project.